Draconia Chronicles: Protagonist Pixel Art Brief

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I am commissioning pixel art of the protagonist of my game, *Draconia Chronicles*, a siege-defense game for phones. The protagonist is the player's own dragon, a fresh graduate of the Dragon Academy who holds the gate of the last city against an apocalyptic horde.

The game's look: the glow of a fireside fantasy painting meets 16-bit pixel art.

The character

The player is the dragon: the player names them, and they are the player's avatar.

- **Name and title:** the player chooses the name. The title grows with the game, from fresh graduate of the Dragon Academy to savior of the world and creator of the final bastion of light. People call them by name, and sometimes by title.
- **Age:** an adult, newly graduated from the Dragon Academy, which trains dragons to defend dragonkind.
- **Marks:** none. No scars; a fresh, shiny graduate.
- **Gender:** deliberately neither.
- **Size:** at least two to three times the size of an adult human man.
- **Body:** four legs plus two wings.
- **Personality:** brave, caring, inspiring.
- **Expression:** kind and caring at rest; fierce and merciless in battle.
- **Story:** far away, the realm's heroes failed to stop a great evil, and the Unmaking was released across the world. The protagonist was at the Academy's graduation ceremony with the last survivors. Ancient magic protected the city of Draconia, but their friends and family, just outside its walls, were unmade before their eyes. When the horde came for the gate, everyone else was frozen by fear or dead, and no other graduate made it inside. The protagonist alone stands at the gate.
- **What they fight for:** the people behind the gate are the last of everything in the world, the most precious thing on the planet. The horde is evil, death and destruction, and wants only to snuff out the last of the world's light.
- **Signature:** the color of their scales. They are the last dragon with scales of this color.

- **Fire:** red and orange, like normal fire, shot as fireballs. Later power-ups may change its color when they draw magic from the pendant. They have no other powers.
- **The pendant:** a gift from the elder dragon, and their heartstone. If they die, the pendant dies; if the pendant is destroyed, they die. It shields them from the Unmaking outside the city, weakens the farther they travel from Draconia, and recharges there.
- **Growth:** their look changes over the game, with upgraded claws, fangs, armor and horns.
- **Must look different from:** dragons corrupted by the purple, dark Unmaking; the bookish librarian dragon of the Librarium; the calm, wise elder dragon; and the stern, serious arcane dragon of the Arcanum.
- **Enemies they face:** kobolds, goblins, shadow crawlers, ash-gray orcs and minotaur bosses, all in pixel art.

Deliverables

Four sprites are required and two animations are optional; please quote each line separately. The game runs on a phone held upright, about 390 points wide, and sprites are always shown at whole-number scales.

#	Sprite	Canvas (px)	Shown at	Pose and where it appears	Priority
1	Portrait bust	48×48 (64×64 if the detail needs it)	3× to 4×	Head and upper neck in profile, facing right. Profile screen, dialogue, journal.	Required
2	Perched full body	128×128	2×	Crouched on top of the city gate, wings folded, facing right toward the horde. The main battle screen.	Required
3	Victory pose	128×128	2×	Front or three-quarter view, wings spread wide, head raised. Victory, rewards and title screens.	Required
4	Head token	32×32	2× to 4×	Head only, readable at 1×. Map marker and tab icon.	Required
5	Idle loop for #2	128×128, 4 to 6 frames	2×	Breathing, a tail flick, a blink.	Optional
6	Fireball attack for #2	128×128, 6 to 8 frames	2×	A fireball on each tap; a bigger one for critical hits.	Optional

Design direction

These notes describe the feeling I am after, the design itself is yours.

When players first see the protagonist, they should feel safe, and proud to be this dragon.

- Noble, not monstrous.
- Powerful, not bulky.
- A guardian, not a beast.
- Kind and caring at rest; fierce and merciless in battle.
- Grand first, playful second.

Must have:

- Four legs and two wings.
- The pendant, their heartstone, visible as part of the design.
- Room to grow: claws, fangs, armor and horns are upgraded over the game.
- A clear difference from the corrupted purple dragons and the rest of the dragon cast.
- A silhouette that reads at small sizes.

Must not be:

- Cute or chibi.
- Skeletal, rotting or grimdark; that is the enemy's look.
- A copy of a dragon from an existing game, film or book.

Beyond these, I welcome your ideas. Feel free to show two or three different directions at the thumbnail stage.

Color

The scale color is the protagonist's signature: they are the last dragon with scales of this color. Warm colors suit them, but the choice is yours; please propose it at the flat-color checkpoint. Their fire is red and orange, like normal fire, and the eyes are open to your proposal.

The palette has to work with what the game already has:

- **Backgrounds:** battles happen at night, against deep blue-violet backgrounds (around #1E1824).

- **Other dragons:** dragons corrupted by the Unmaking are purple and dark. The scale color must differ from theirs and from the other dragons in the cast.
- **Enemies:** the horde is ash gray with violet corruption.
- **Interface:** bright red means health and danger, and gold marks important actions.

Technical specs

Spec	Requirement
Style	Pixel art in your own style
Facing	Right, for every sprite except the victory pose.
Background	Transparent, with hard pixel edges. No soft anti-aliasing into the background.
Palette	One shared palette of about 20 colors across all sprites.
Scaling	Delivered at 1×. The game scales by whole numbers (2×, 3×, 4×), so nothing may rely on fractional scaling.
Readability	Each sprite must read as the same dragon at 1×.
Files	Layered source files (Aseprite preferred), a PNG at 1× for each sprite, and a horizontal sprite strip for each animation with frame timings in milliseconds.
Palette file	The final palette as a .hex or .gpl file.

Process

I review every checkpoint myself and reply within 24 hours, by email and or discord (we can agree which way works best for you). Please wait for approval at each checkpoint before starting the next one.

1. **Thumbnails:** a few silhouette options for the perched pose and the victory pose, in flat black at 1×.
2. **Portrait:** the head bust in flat colors, then fully rendered.

3. **Perched full body:** flat colors on the chosen pose, then fully rendered. The head must match the portrait.
4. **Victory pose and head token:** flat colors, then fully rendered.
5. **Animations, if commissioned:** key poses first, then in-betweens.
6. **Delivery:** source files, PNGs, sprite strips and the palette file.

Terms

- **Rights:** full ownership of the delivered art.
- **Portfolio:** you may show the work in your portfolio whenever you like.
- **Credit:** you will be credited in the game.
- **AI:** Use not allowed.
- **NDA:** none required.
- **Quote:** please price each deliverable separately, say how many revision rounds each checkpoint includes, and give a turnaround for each checkpoint.

Thank you!